

How do I secure a REST API with JWT?

I am building a Node.js REST API and want to secure protected routes using JSON Web Token (JWT) authentication. I would like to understand the complete authentication flow, including:

- How users authenticate and receive a JWT after login.
- How the token is sent with subsequent requests.
- How middleware verifies and validates the token before granting access to protected resources.
- How to securely store JWT secrets and configure token expiration.
- How to handle invalid, expired, or missing tokens.
- Best practices for protecting user data and preventing common security vulnerabilities.

What are the key steps and recommended practices for implementing JWT authentication securely in a Node.js REST API?